■ CASHQUEST KIDS

flexlifefi.com

BUILDING FINANCIAL CONFIDENCE

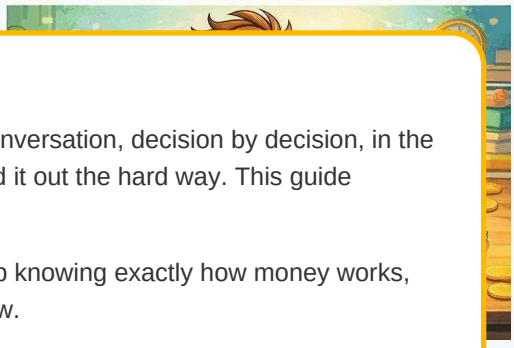
An Age-by-Age Parent Guide

Birth through High School · All 6 CashQuest Worlds

Ages 4-6 | Ages 7-9 | Ages 10-12 | Ages 13-15 | Ages 16-18

Welcome, Parent.

You're already doing the most important thing: showing up.



A Note From the CashQuest Team

Financial confidence isn't something children stumble into — it's built, conversation by conversation, decision by decision, in the moments parents create intentionally. Most of us weren't taught this in school. We figured it out the hard way. This guide changes that for your family.

CashQuest Kids was designed with one belief at its core: every child deserves to grow up knowing exactly how money works, how to make it grow, and how to use it to build a life they love. Not someday. Starting now.

This guide walks you through exactly what to teach at every age — the right conversations, the right activities, and the Pro Tips that make the difference. Use it at the dinner table, in the car, or on a Saturday morning. No finance degree required.

— The CashQuest Kids Team · flexlifefi.com

How to Use This Guide

Read Your Age Section

Find your child's age band and start there. Each section stands alone.

Use the Conversation Starters

Real scripts you can use word-for-word. No prep needed.

Try One Activity This Week

Start small. One activity done beats ten planned.

Share a Pro Tip

Each Pro Tip took a real parent years to figure out. Use it now.

Come Back Each Year

Children grow. Revisit the next age band as they're ready.

The 6 CashQuest Worlds — Your Child's Financial Journey

EARN
Earning, work, value of money

SAVE
Saving, goals, delayed gratification

BUILD
Budgets, business, entr epreneurship

BANK
Banking, credit, financial systems

INVEST
Stocks, compound growth, long-term wealth

GIVE
Generosity, community, legacy

Ages 4-6

Kindergarten & Pre-K · World 1: Earning Foundations

Core Teaching Points

1. Money is earned through work and effort — not just given
2. Coins and bills have different values; we can count them
3. Saving means choosing to wait before spending
4. Needs (food, shelter) are different from wants (toys, treats)
5. Giving is part of how we use money wisely
6. Work has worth — our effort creates real value

PRO TIPS

★ Use a clear glass jar instead of a piggy bank so children can literally watch savings grow. Visibility creates belief.

★ When paying allowance, pay in coins and small bills. The physical act of holding and counting money builds number sense AND financial instinct simultaneously.

★ Play "store" at home with real money. Let your child be the cashier AND the customer. Real transaction practice beats worksheets every time.

REAL SCENARIOS

SITUATION:
Your child asks for a toy at the store and has a meltdown when you say no.

TRY THIS:
Say: "You could earn this! You have $2 saved. This costs $8. That's $6 more. What jobs could you do?" Turn the tantrum into a plan.

SITUATION:
Your child finds a dollar on the ground and wants to keep it all.

TRY THIS:
Introduce the 3-jar split: "Let's put 50¢ in savings, 25¢ to spend, 25¢ to give. Which jar do you want to fill first?"

AGE-DIRECTED ACTIVITIES

Coin Sorting Game
Sort a jar of coins by type. Count each pile. Which pile has the most money vs most coins?
■ 20 min

Play Store
Set up a "store" at home with priced items. Practice making change with real coins.
■ 30 min

Chore Chart + Jar
Create 3 labeled jars: Save, Spend, Give. Pay tiny amounts for real completed tasks.
■ Ongoing

Library Book Bag
Check out a money-themed picture book. Read together, pause & ask questions about characters' choices.
■ 15 min

CONVERSATION STARTERS

- *"Where do you think money comes from?"*
- *"If you had $1, what would you do with it?"*
- *"What's something you want to save up for?"*
- *"Why do you think people work?"*

COMMON MISTAKES TO AVOID

- ✗ Giving money with no connection to effort
- ✗ Using "we can't afford it" (say "we choose to spend differently")
- ✗ Shielding kids from ALL money conversations
- ✗ Making saving feel like punishment

Ages 7-9

Grades 1-3 · World 2: Saving Superpowers

Core Teaching Points

1. Earning comes from effort, skills, and serving others' needs
2. The 50/30/20 rule: Needs, Wants, Savings applied to allowance
3. Delayed gratification is a trainable superpower
4. Comparison shopping — unit price, quality, and value
5. Starting a micro-business (lemonade, pet sitting, crafts)
6. Banking basics: why savings accounts exist and what interest means

PRO TIPS

★ Help your child set a specific savings goal with a picture and a timeline. Vague goals ("save money") fail. "I'm saving for the Lego set ($34) in 6 weeks" works.

★ Let them make a small bad purchase. The $4 toy that breaks in a day teaches more than any lecture. Resist the urge to say "I told you so." Ask: "What would you do differently?"

★ Introduce "interest" with a family bank. Pay 10% per month on their savings balance. Watching their money earn money is electrifying at this age.

REAL SCENARIOS

SITUATION:
Your child wants to spend their entire savings on a new video game the moment they have enough money.

TRY THIS:
"This is your money and your choice. Before you decide — if you wait one more week you'll have $12 extra. Want to look at your options?" Respect their choice either way.

SITUATION:
Your child wants to start a "business" selling artwork at school.

TRY THIS:
"That's an amazing idea. Let's figure out your costs first. How much do supplies cost? What would you charge? Could you make a profit?" Walk through it with real numbers.

AGE-DIRECTED ACTIVITIES

3-Jar Budget
Set up Spend/Save/Give jars. Every time they receive money, split it together using the 50/30/20 rule.
■ Every payday

Grocery Store Math
Give them $20 at the store. Have them find the best value on 3 items using unit price labels.
■ 45 min

Mini Business Plan
Help them plan a lemonade stand or pet-sitting service: costs, pricing, profit calculation.
■ 1 hour

Goal Thermometer
Draw a thermometer showing savings progress toward a specific goal. Color it in weekly.
■ Ongoing

CONVERSATION STARTERS

- *"What's something you could do to earn $10 this week — not from us?"*
- *"If you save $5 every week, how many weeks until you reach your goal?"*
- *"What's the difference between something you NEED and something you WANT?"*
- *"If you started a business, what would you sell and who would buy it?"*

COMMON MISTAKES TO AVOID

- ✗ Rescuing bad financial decisions with your own money
- ✗ Tying all money to chores (some chores = family responsibility)
- ✗ Vague savings goals with no deadline or visual tracker
- ✗ Skipping the "cost of supplies" step in business ideas

■ Ages 10-12

Grades 4-6 · World 3: Building & Budgeting

■ Core Teaching Points

1. Budget creation: tracking income and expenses over time
2. Profit = Revenue minus Cost — applied to real scenarios
3. Entrepreneurship mindset: identifying problems worth solving
4. Compound interest: the math of exponential money growth
5. Credit basics: what it is, how it's earned, how it can hurt
6. Comparing prices across stores and online — smart spending

■ PRO TIPS

★ Open a real savings account with your child and make THEM responsible for depositing money and tracking the balance. Ownership changes everything.

★ Run the compound interest calculator together. Show what $1,000 becomes in 30 years at 7%. Then show what happens if they start at 30 instead of 20. The gap is the lesson.

★ Challenge them with real family budget categories. "We budget $400/month for groceries for our family. How would YOU spend it?" Real numbers, real problem — massive engagement.

■ REAL SCENARIOS

SITUATION:
Your child wants to buy something online and is confused about why prices differ across websites.

TRY THIS:
"Let's search three places. Copy the prices into this notebook. Now add shipping. Now check reviews. What's the TRUE best deal?" Teach research as a habit, not a one-time lesson.

SITUATION:
Your child wants to start a real business and needs startup money.

TRY THIS:
"Great. Write me a one-page business plan: What are you selling? Who buys it? What do supplies cost? What do you charge? When do you break even?" Then consider a small family loan — WITH repayment terms.

■ AGE-DIRECTED ACTIVITIES

Real Budget Challenge
Give them one real family budget category for one week. Let them manage it. Review together at the end.
■ 1 week

Compound Interest Lab
Use a calculator: $1,000 × 1.07^30. Compare starting at 10, 20, 30. Chart the results visually.
■ 30 min

Business Plan Draft
Write a 1-page business plan for a real micro-business. Include costs, revenue, and profit target.
■ 1-2 hrs

Price Research Project
Pick any item they want to buy. Research 5 sources. Build a simple comparison spreadsheet.
■ 45 min

■ CONVERSATION STARTERS

- *"If I gave you $1,000 today, what would you do with it and why?"*
- *"Can you tell me one problem our neighborhood has that someone could solve and make money doing it?"*
- *"What do you think a credit score is and why would it matter?"*
- *"If you could own any business in the world when you grow up, what would it be?"*

■ COMMON MISTAKES TO AVOID

- ✗ Doing their budget FOR them instead of guiding from behind
- ✗ Teaching credit as purely negative before teaching its power
- ✗ Missing the compound interest window — this is the PRIME age to show the math
- ✗ Not including them in real family financial decisions appropriate for their age

Ages 13-15

Grades 7-9 · World 4: Banking & Credit

Core Teaching Points

1. How to open and manage a real bank account independently
2. Understanding credit cards, APR, and the true cost of debt
3. Income taxes: what they are, how they're calculated, W-4 basics
4. First job financial planning: saving % from every paycheck
5. Building a personal brand and entrepreneurial identity
6. Investment vehicles: savings accounts, CDs, intro to stocks

PRO TIPS

★ When they get their first job, require a savings percentage commitment BEFORE the first check arrives. 20-30% non-negotiable. Making it a habit from check #1 is the most powerful financial move they'll ever make.

★ Run a credit card simulation: Give them a "credit card" for one month's spending on discretionary items — then show the bill. Apply 20% APR interest if not paid in full. The shock is the lesson.

★ Take them to the bank together to open their first account — but make them do ALL the talking. Prepare them, then step back. Ownership comes from doing, not watching.

REAL SCENARIOS

SITUATION:

Your teenager gets their first paycheck and immediately wants to spend it all.

TRY THIS:

"Before you spend anything — what's your savings goal this month? Let's transfer that first, right now, before you touch the rest. The transfer takes 30 seconds and changes your whole financial life."

SITUATION:

Your teen is considering taking on a credit card for "emergencies."

TRY THIS:

"Let's run the math on a $500 balance with 22% APR with minimum payments only." Pull out a calculator together. When they see the real payoff timeline and total interest paid, they'll understand what you're protecting them from.

AGE-DIRECTED ACTIVITIES

Bank Account Setup

Go together. Let them fill out all paperwork. They ask the questions, manage the account.

1-2 hrs

Credit Card Sim

Simulate one month of credit spending with 22% APR. Calculate real payoff cost.

45 min

Paycheck Planning

Using their real or projected paycheck, build a full monthly budget before first day of work.

1 hour

Stock Market Intro

Give $100 of "paper money" to invest in 3 stocks. Track for 60 days. Discuss decisions.

60 days

CONVERSATION STARTERS

- *"If you save 25% of every paycheck from now until you're 22, what would you have?"*
- *"What would you do if you lost your job or income unexpectedly? Do you have a plan?"*
- *"What's the difference between an asset and a liability?"*
- *"If you could build any kind of financial life by 35, what does it look like?"*

COMMON MISTAKES TO AVOID

- ✗ Not requiring a savings % commitment before first paycheck
- ✗ Paying off teen debts or bailing them out of poor spending choices
- ✗ Teaching investing as "too risky" rather than "manageable with knowledge"
- ✗ Skipping tax literacy — they'll be blindsided at their first job

■ Ages 16-18

Grades 10-12 · World 5-6: Investing & Legacy

■ Core Teaching Points

1. Long-term investing: index funds, IRAs, compound growth math
2. The true cost of college: loans, interest, return-on-investment
3. Net worth: assets vs. liabilities and building a personal balance sheet
4. Real estate as a wealth vehicle: how leverage and equity work
5. Side income streams: the difference between linear and scalable income
6. Financial independence: defining YOUR number and your timeline

■ PRO TIPS

★ Open a Roth IRA with their first W-2 income. Even $500 at 17 compounding 50 years is extraordinary. The earlier the better, no exceptions.

★ Show them your own net worth statement. The transparency is more powerful than any lecture. Kids who see parents' real financial picture make better decisions as adults.

★ Make them calculate the ROI of their own college plan. "This degree costs $X, pays average $Y/year. What's the break-even?" Not to discourage college — to teach investment thinking applied to their biggest life decision.

■ REAL SCENARIOS

SITUATION:
Your teen has $2,000 saved and wants to know where to put it.

TRY THIS:
"Let's think about this as an investor, not a saver. How much do you need liquid for emergencies? Let's put 3 months of expenses in HYSA, the rest into a Roth IRA index fund. Let me show you what that's worth when you're 65."

SITUATION:
Your teen is getting pressure to choose the most expensive college on their acceptance list.

TRY THIS:
"Let's build a spreadsheet. Cost of attendance, minus scholarships, equals loan amount. Then we calculate monthly payments and salary projections for that career. The math tells the story."

■ AGE-DIRECTED ACTIVITIES

Roth IRA Setup
Open a custodial Roth IRA together with their first earned W-2 income. Even $100 to start.
■ 1-2 hrs

Net Worth Statement
Build their first personal balance sheet: list every asset and every liability. Calculate net worth.
■ 45 min

College ROI Analysis
Build a real spreadsheet: 4-year cost vs. projected salary for 3 different paths. Compare breakeven.
■ 1-2 hrs

FI Number Calc
Calculate their Financial Independence number using 25x annual expenses rule at flexlifefi.com
■ 30 min

■ CONVERSATION STARTERS

- *"If you never had to work for money again, what would you do with your time?"*
- *"What's the difference between being rich and being wealthy?"*
- *"If you could build one income stream that worked while you slept, what would it be?"*
- *"What does financial freedom mean to YOU — and by what age?"*

■ COMMON MISTAKES TO AVOID

- ✗ Waiting until "they're older" to open investment accounts — time is the asset
- ✗ Not showing them your own real financial picture — transparency teaches more than theory
- ✗ Framing all debt as bad instead of teaching strategic vs. destructive debt
- ✗ Skipping the FI conversation — most teens have NEVER heard of financial independence

■ MONEY CONVERSATION CHEAT SHEET

Print this page. Put it on the fridge. Use it this week.

AGES 4-6

At the store: *"Do you know how much this costs? Let's count it together."*

Finding coins: *"What coin is this? How much is it worth? Can you sort them?"*

After chores: *"You earned this. It's yours because of your work — not just given."*

AGES 7-9

Savings goal: *"What are you saving for? How many weeks until you have enough?"*

Allowance day: *"How are you splitting this — spend, save, or give? Let's use the jars."*

Store trip: *"Is this a need or a want? How do you know the difference?"*

AGES 10-12

Family budget: *"We spend about $X on groceries. Can you find ways to save $20 this week?"*

Side hustle: *"You could earn money doing X. What would it actually cost to start?"*

Math moment: *"If you saved $5 every week for one year, how much would you have?"*

AGES 13-15

Bank account: *"Let's open a real account together this weekend. You'll be in charge."*

Credit cards: *"What happens if someone only ever pays the minimum? Let's calculate it."*

First job: *"Before you touch your check — what percentage are we saving first?"*

AGES 16-18

Investing: *"If you put $1,000 in an index fund today and left it 30 years — guess the total."*

College costs: *"Here's the actual loan amount. Let's calculate what the monthly payment would b*

■ The 15 Most Powerful Pro Tips — All Ages

Field-tested. Parent-proven. Start with #1 this week.

1 Make money visible
Use clear jars, not piggy banks. Kids need to SEE savings grow to believe it works.

2 Name the why first
Before any money lesson, ask: "What do YOU want?" Goal-first learning sticks 10x better.

3 Pay immediately
When a child earns money, pay the same day. Delayed rewards teach nothing at young ages.

4 Use real money
App money is invisible. Coins and bills create physical memory. Go tangible until age 12.

5 Let them make mistakes
Let them buy the cheap toy that breaks. That lesson costs $3 and lasts a lifetime.

6 Never rescue bad decisions
If they blow their savings, don't top it up. The discomfort IS the education.

7 Shop math everywhere
Grocery stores are classrooms. "Which is cheaper per ounce?" teaches more than textbooks.

8 Talk income openly
Kids who know roughly what parents earn develop better financial perspective. Don't hide it.

9 Tie giving to earning
Generosity taught alongside earning creates givers for life, not just compliers.

10 Celebrate first investments
When a teen makes their first investment, make it a big deal. Frame it as a rite of passage.

11 Use the "time machine" question
Ask: "What would 30-years-from-now you think of this decision?" Changes everything.

12 Never say "we can't afford it"
Say "we're choosing to spend our money differently." Abundance mindset starts with language.

13 Make the invisible visible
Show compound interest on a calculator. Watching $1,000 become $7,600 is life-changing.

14 Normalize failure
Share your own money mistakes. Kids who see parents recover from failure learn resilience.

15 Create a family money mission
"Our family builds wealth to ___." Fill in the blank together. Post it. Live it.

Ready for the Full Journey?

Everything in this guide connects to the full CashQuest Kids curriculum — 6 Worlds, 72 vocabulary terms, worksheets, activities, and the complete app experience. All free.

- **CashQuest Kids App**
  iOS App Store — Search "CashQuest Kids"
- **Full Resource Library**
  Worksheets, flashcards, coloring books
- **Parent Guides (All 6)**
  One per CashQuest World
- **Teacher Curriculum**
  6-Week complete unit with assessments
- **FlexLifeFI Tools**
  FI Calculator, Debt Snowball & more

Everything starts here:

FlexLifeFI.com

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